

WINGED ARMOUR An Indian soldier operates a drone near the LoC in Uri sector in Kashmir, Aug. 12

PTI

DEFENCE | UAVs

BUILDING A DRONE FORCE

The Indian army has ambitious plans to raise specialised drone warfare units equipped with indigenous UAVs. But India's drone industry needs extra support to overcome procedural, financial and technical hurdles

BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

If **THERE WAS A MAJOR LESSON FOR INDIA FROM OPERATION SINDOOR**, it was the need to upgrade its drone power—both in terms of a strike force and in defending itself against enemy Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs). In fact, battlefields have been transformed by drones, which are now indispensable for ISR (Intelligence-Surveillance-Reconnaissance) through medium/ high altitude drones, or for precise strike missions through battlefield support UAVs armed with bombs and missiles. During the short and sharp conflict between India and Pakistan from May 7-10, another form of attack drones gained prominence. Known as loitering munitions or fire-and-forget 'kamikaze' UAVs, these are armed with warheads that 'loiter' over an area before identifying and swooping down on targets—often used in 'swarms' to overwhelm air defences and pulverise enemy assets. The high level of integration of these range